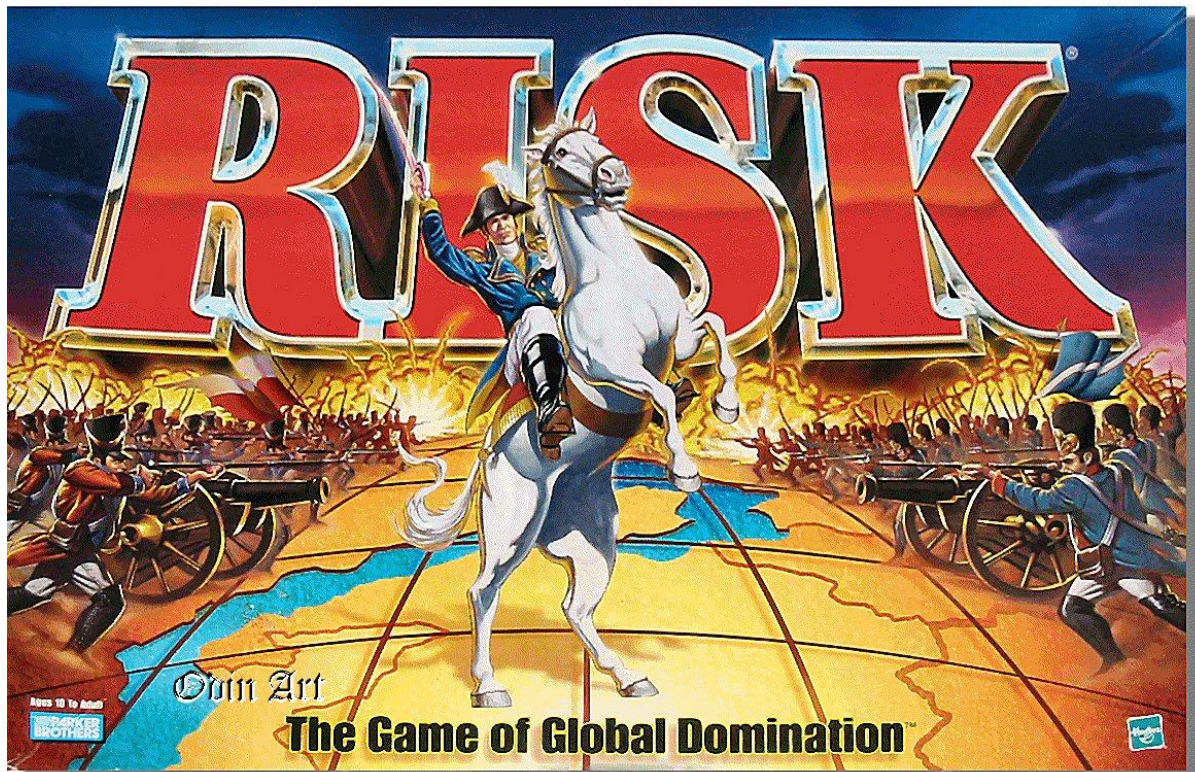


ASSIGNMENT 2: GAME DESIGN ESSAY

What if Risk was Solarpunk?



I. Overview

Risk is a popular strategy-based war game that was created by the French filmmaker Albert Lamorisse and first released internationally in 1959 by Parker Brothers, where players compete for world domination.

For two to six players, the standard version of the game features a tri-fold game board (world map with territories), five dice (2 white and 2 red), a deck of 56 Risk cards, six coloured sets of armies.

The main goal of the game is to conquer and control most of the territories on a world map with armies represented by coloured markers. Each player starts with a certain number of armies, which are used to attack or defend their territory from other players. They gain additional army pieces based on the number of occupied territories, the value of the controlled continents, the value of the traded cards and the territory pictured on the card. There are 42 territories grouped into six continents. Players take turns, controlling their armies. They attempt to capture territories from other players, with results determined by dice rolls (number of dice rolled based on the size of the armies in battle). The game ends when one player has eliminated all other players and controlled the 42 territories.

In this essay, we will analyse the conservative nature of this boardgame and try to solve these by transforming its values towards more modern/liberal ideologies.

II. Conservative Patterns and Mechanics

Risk features strong conservative ideologies in its overall theme, mechanics, and gameplay. We can even argue that Risk is based on Expansionist Nationalist approach, a radical form of nationalism.

Conservative Mechanics:

- **Territory control:** Each territory can have armies placed on it. Players collect these armies by rolling dice, and they move their armies across the board to capture territories. The more armies a player has in a territory, the harder it is for other players to attack and capture it. Parallely, the more controlled territories, the more armies are given to the player each turn.
- **Card play:** The game also involves cards that represent different military sizes (infantry, cavalry, and artillery) as well as special actions like "attack" or "fortify".
- **Strategic planning:** Capturing certain territories offer bonus armies or cards.
- **Diplomacy:** Players can form alliances with other players to divide their enemies and take down a more powerful player together, but these alliances are often short-lived as each player tries to advance their own goals.
- **Endgame:** The game ends when one player controls all territories on the board and eliminates all other players.

Some of its core principles reflect militaristic and expansionist values, which could be perceived as conservative ideologies as well. These include:

1. Survival of the fittest:

All players begin with an equal number of armies and territories, creating a sense of meritocracy where hard work and clever strategy can lead to victory. The game emphasizes the idea that only the strongest and most cunning players will succeed, reflecting a competitive environment where only the best survives.

Additionally, the rule of the monopoly governs. The more territories a player achieves to control, the more armies they will earn each turn and more power they will have, therefore making them even more difficult to overthrow by the other players.

2. Expansionism:

Players are encouraged to constantly expand their territories at the expense of others, promoting the belief in manifest destiny or the notion that certain nations or people have the right to conquer new lands for progress and civilization.

Risk encourages aggressive behaviour among players to achieve dominance. This can perpetuate the belief that competition and conflict are necessary for progress and success.

3. Limited government intervention:

In Risk, there is no involvement from any "higher power" such as a governing body or global organization, which leaves the players to govern themselves according to their own rules.

4. Power through force and control:

The game teaches that having a strong military presence and controlling more territories than rivals are the key to success. This reflects the belief in might-makes-right ideology.

5. Reinforcement of hierarchical structures:

The game's structure inherently creates a hierarchy among players, with one player ultimately controlling the majority of territories. This could be seen as promoting traditional power dynamics and reinforcing the notion that only a few should hold significant control over resources.

Based on those mechanics and values, we can conclude that RISK takes core nationalistic idea of the nation-state, self-determination, militarism, expansionism and even chauvism. Now that this is established, we are going to navigate through some design solutions that aim at resolving this Expansionist Nationalism and steer the game towards a Solarpunk ideology.

III. Design Solutions

To address these conservative-nationalist ideologies, we can reimagine Risk with a Solarpunk theme. Solarpunk refers to an artistic movement that envisions sustainable future closely connected with nature and community. Generally, it is portrayed with a harmonious coexistence of technology and nature, such as solar panels among roof gardens on eco-friendly buildings. It also tries to address contemporary challenges such as pollution and climate change. It stands in contrast to cyberpunk, its dystopian version where technology is exploited by oppressive forces and society collapses.

A solarpunk version of Risk would incorporate elements of sustainability, renewable energy, and eco-friendly practices into the game's mechanics and objectives. Note that the following solutions provide numbers, but they were not tested nor balanced for adequate gameplay, these are only theoretical.

Cooperative gameplay:

Instead of players competing against each other, they will work together to achieve common goals. The Earth is dying, and together, the players must save the planet by developing and using strategically the resources at their disposal in the territories on the world map.

Flattening the hierarchy:

Now that players have a common goal and that the game asks for cooperation to win, there are no significant domination. More resourceful nations will have to help the others as it is in their interest to win the game together.

Here are the resources which the player will have to play with and gather to progress:

- Research Points (RP) – used to develop territories infrastructures and improve Knowledge to have access to more territories, and thus better EP generation.
- Eco Points (EP) – These are the Victory Points, gather them (target: 400) to save the world!
- Knowledge – Ability for a player to have access to a territory.
- Technology – Cards would be changed to represent different forms of technology such as wind farms, solar panels, hydroponics, etc.

Territories:

There are different types of territories for the player to exploit in order to save the world, each having their own pros and cons based on their generation rate of Research Points (RP) and Eco Points (EP).

- **Fossil Energy Territory**

Point Generation: +10 Research Points (RP) per turn, but -5 Eco-Points (EP) due to environmental degradation.

Description: This territory is rich in fossil fuels, providing a quick energy boost for the player. However, its extraction and use harm the environment, decreasing eco-points.

- **Sustainable Energy Territory**

Point Generation: +3 RP per turn, +2 EP

Description: This territory generates sustainable energy, contributing to the player's research points while also increasing their eco-points.

- **Agricultural Territory**

Point Generation: +2 RP per turn, +1 EP (if agricultural practices are sustainable)

Description: This territory allows players to grow food and other resources, providing a steady source of research points. If sustainable agricultural practices are used, the territory also earns eco-points.

- **Natural Reserve Territory**

Point Generation: 0 RP per turn, +3 EP

Description: This territory focuses on conservation efforts, protecting wildlife habitats and preserving natural resources. Players earn research points while also increasing their eco-points.

Players have the possibility to enhance their territories by developing them with infrastructures, thus improving their Point Generation.

Acquire a territory:

For a player to have access to a territory and develop it, they will need to have the necessary Knowledge and luck. Thanks to RP, players can increase their Knowledge, and by using dice and throwing them, this will or will not uncover an untouched land for the player to develop.

Randomness:

Each territory, based on their benefits, will have a certain demand for Knowledge in order to access them. Player's Knowledge will be used as a basis for comparison with the "power" of the territory, and throwing dices, for both parties (territory and player) will determine the winning side for this "attempt for access".

Develop a territory:

Players will have the opportunity to improve the infrastructures on their territories if they have enough RP and Knowledge. A wind farm for example can only be developed on a Sustainable Energy Territory and would cost a player 5 RP and a Knowledge level of 2.

Global fund:

The game would implement a system where players can contribute to a global fund by sharing RPs that can help disadvantaged territories to develop. This would create a change in the game dynamics.

Crises:

Each 5 turn, one player will draw from the Crisis Deck, which is an additional card deck that introduces random events to influence gameplay, such as natural disasters or global crises. The crisis drawn will affect all players equally, as a “global event”, potentially requiring them to use the global funds to recover.

The effect of a crisis will depend on the type of event that is drawn, but will basically deplete the stock of RP and EP. For example, a cricket swarm can take place and therefore impact agricultural territories. As a result, there will be deducted RP and EP from each player.

Winning the game:

To reach the winning state, the total amount of Eco Points shared among the players should reach the target to save the planet. This target would be of 400 EP (only theoretical as the game would need tests and balancing to find the appropriate number).

IV. Conclusion

In conclusion, to challenge the conservative patterns and mechanics rooted in the expansionist nationalistic nature of Risk, we transformed the classic game into a solarpunk-themed experience that now promotes community, sustainable, and eco-friendly vision of gameplay.

By incorporating elements such as sustainable energy production, cooperative gameplay, flattening hierarchies, and addressing global crises, the redesigned game aligns with the principles of solarpunk ideology, which emphasizes harmony with nature and community-driven progress.

This theoretical redesign can serve as an interesting example of how games can be made to reflect contemporary values and inspire players to be critical of more classic games.

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